

Teacher FAQ: 25 Tough Questions Kids Ask

Teacher Support

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

TEACHER'S COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Hackles Teacher Support Pack, Document 2 of 5.

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How to use this FAQ

KIDS ASK HARD QUESTIONS, often at awkward moments. Each question below has four honest answers, one for each grade band: **K-2** (ages 5-7), **3-5** (8-10), **6-8** (11-13), and **9-12** (14-18). Use the wording for the band you teach, or adapt it in your own voice.

Ground rules that apply to every answer:

- **Be honest and calm.** "I don't know, let's find out together" is a good answer. Do not invent facts.
- **Never blame.** If a question is about something that happened to the child or a friend, thank them for asking and keep the focus on what helps.
- **Answer the question asked.** Give the smallest true answer that fits the child's age. Do not volunteer graphic detail.
- **Watch for the real question.** A question that begins "My friend..." or "What if someone..." may be about the child. Quietly offer a private follow-up: "That's a really good question. Want to talk about it more, just us, after class?"
- **If it sounds like a disclosure,** switch to the Disclosure and Incident Guide. Do not wait.
- **Statistics and laws change.** Where an answer includes a figure or legal claim, it is marked [VERIFY]. Confirm with the primary source and your district before using it.
- **Consult policy and counsel** for anything about your reporting duties or student discipline.

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01 Will I get in trouble if I tell?

K-2: "No. Telling a grown-up when something feels yucky or scary is never getting in trouble. It is exactly what we want you to do."

3-5: "No. Telling is never the thing that gets you in trouble. Even if you made a mistake, the grown-ups' first job is to help you and keep you safe. Our school wants you to tell."

6-8: "Telling about something that happened to you will not get you punished for being targeted. If rules were broken, like a device rule, the adults can handle that separately, and many schools treat help-seeking as the priority. I can't promise what every adult will do, but I can promise I will be on your side and will help you work out what comes next." (Be honest if school policy requires discipline for a specific behavior, and consult policy.)

9-12: "Being a victim of manipulation, threats, or image abuse isn't something you get disciplined for. If your own choices raise a policy issue, that conversation is usually separate from getting you help, and I'll tell you up front what I'm required to share and with whom. I can't promise secrecy, but I can promise to help you through it." [Consult policy and counsel on discipline and reporting.]

02 Why can't I just keep my password the same everywhere?

K-2: "A password is like the key to your house. If you gave the same key copy to lots of people, it would be easier for someone to get in. Keep your password secret, and only share it with the grown-up who helps you."

3-5: "If one website gets broken into and you used the same password everywhere, someone could try it on your other accounts. A long passphrase of random words that is different for each important account protects you better."

6-8: "When a company is breached, criminals try the leaked passwords on other sites. That is called password reuse, and it is one of the most common ways accounts get taken over. Use a different long passphrase for important accounts, and turn on two-step verification where you can."

9-12: "Credential reuse lets one breach unlock many accounts. A password manager gives each account a unique password, and passkeys remove the password altogether on supported sites. Prioritize your email, since it can reset everything else."

03 Why can't I talk to people I meet in games?

K-2: "You can play games with grown-ups and friends your parent knows. If someone you don't know in a game asks you personal stuff, or wants to talk privately, stop and tell a grown-up. A game friend might not be who they say."

3-5: "You can have fun in games. The tricky part is that you can't be sure who is behind a name. If someone asks where you live or what school you go to, wants you to keep secrets, or asks you to switch to another app, that is a red flag. Pause, don't answer, and tell a trusted adult."

6-8: "Online friendships can be real and positive. It's still true that anyone can pretend to be anyone online, and some adults pretend to be kids. The warning signs are pushing to move to a private app, secrecy, gifts or game currency, flattery that escalates, and requests for pictures. When you see these, you can stop, block, and tell someone, and you will never be in trouble for it."

9-12: "You don't need to be paranoid, but treat an online-only contact's identity as unverified. Patterns to notice: rapid intimacy, a push to move to a private or less-moderated app, secrecy, gifts, boundary testing, and requests for images. Those patterns matter more than whether the person is a 'stranger.' If you see them, save the conversation, stop, block, report, and tell someone."

04 What if my friend asks me to keep a secret?

K-2: "Some secrets are fun, like a birthday surprise. A secret that makes your tummy feel funny, or that someone says you must never tell a grown-up, is not okay. You tell a grown-up about those."

3-5: "There are happy secrets that end in a surprise, and there are worry secrets. If a secret is about someone being hurt, scared, or asked for pictures, tell a trusted adult. You are not breaking a promise. You are being a good friend."

6-8: "Loyalty matters, and so does safety. If keeping a secret means someone could be hurt, threatened, or is hurting themselves, telling a trusted adult is the caring thing to do, even if they are angry for a while. You can say to your friend, 'I care about you too much to keep this one.'"

9-12: "Confidentiality between friends is a normal, good thing, with limits. When the secret involves risk of serious harm, such as self-harm, abuse, exploitation or threats, you are not obligated to carry it alone. Bringing in a trusted adult is the right call, and you can tell your friend before or after, using 'I'm worried about you' language."

05 Is it my fault if someone is mean to me online?

K-2: "No. Mean words are the mean person's choice. It is never your fault. Tell a grown-up so they can help."

3-5: "No. Someone else chose to be mean. You can save the message, block them, and tell a trusted adult. Nobody deserves to be treated that way."

6-8: "No. Bullying is a choice by the person doing it, and being targeted is not a reflection on you. Screenshot or save it, block or mute, tell a trusted adult, and report it to the platform. It follows you home online, which is why asking for help matters."

9-12: "No. Responsibility lies with the person doing the harm. Document it, report it on the platform, and tell a trusted adult. If it includes threats, hate, or sexual content, the school or law enforcement may need to be involved, and I can help with that."

06 What if someone sent me a picture I didn't want?

K-2: "Close it or look away, and tell a grown-up right away. You did nothing wrong, and you will not be in trouble."

3-5: "Don't share it with anyone, and don't keep looking at it. Show a trusted adult or tell them about it. Telling is the right thing, and you are not in trouble."

6-8: "That is not your fault. Don't forward it to anyone, even as a joke or to show a friend, because sharing certain images of minors can be illegal [Law varies by state; confirm with district counsel]. Block the sender, and tell a trusted adult. If it shows someone who looks under 18, an adult needs to report it."

9-12: "Don't forward, post, or screenshot it. Block, report on the platform, and tell a trusted adult. If it appears to show a minor, forwarding it can be a serious legal problem even if you meant well, so let the adult or authorities handle it. If the sender is someone pressuring you, tell someone and keep the conversation, not the image, as evidence." [VERIFY state law; consult counsel.]

07 What if I already sent a picture?

K-2: (Only if raised) "If you ever share a picture and then feel worried, tell a grown-up. They will help, and you won't be in trouble."

3-5: "If you sent a picture of yourself to someone and now feel worried, tell a trusted adult right away. They will help you. You are not in trouble."

6-8: "Thank you for trusting me enough to ask. First, it is not your fault, especially if you were pressured or tricked. Don't send more, don't pay, and tell a trusted adult now. There are free tools that can help get images taken down, and adults can help you use them."

9-12: "It is not your fault, and you have more options than it feels like you do. Stop responding, don't pay anything, save the messages and account names, and tell a trusted adult. NCMEC's Take It Down service can help remove images of people who were under 18 when the image was made [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: takeitdown.ncmec.org], and platforms have reporting tools. Federal law now also requires covered platforms to have a removal process for non-consensual intimate images and to act within 48 hours of a valid request; this took effect May 19, 2026 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: ftc.gov Take It Down Act guidance]. If it is not safe to tell family, tell me, a counselor, or call the helpline, and we will take the next steps together."

08 What is sextortion, and could it happen to me?

K-2: (Not taught by name at this age.) If asked: "Some people online are tricky and ask for pictures or secrets. Nobody ever needs pictures of your body. If anyone asks, tell a grown-up."

3-5: (Not taught by name; use the body safety framing.) "Some people online pretend to be kids, ask for pictures, and then threaten to be mean if you don't do what they say. That is never your fault. If anyone asks for private pictures or threatens you, stop, and tell a trusted adult right away."

6-8: "Sextortion is when someone threatens to share a private or fake picture unless you send money or more pictures. It often starts with a fake account that seems friendly. It can happen to anyone, and the person doing it is the one breaking the law. The plan is STOP, SAVE, TELL, REPORT, and nothing bad you were told will happen is worth keeping it secret."

9-12: "Financially motivated sextortion is a widespread scheme where offenders, often posing as an attractive peer, get an image or claim to have one, then demand payment or more images. It is targeted heavily at teen boys, but anyone can be affected [VERIFY with current NCMEC and FBI data]. Paying usually does not stop the demands. Stop communicating, keep the evidence, report to the platform and NCMEC's CyberTipline, use Take It

Down, and tell a trusted adult. If you feel hopeless, call or text 988 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 988lifeline.org]."

09 Should I pay if someone is threatening me?

K-2: (Not applicable; if raised) "Never give anyone money or gift cards because they scare you. Tell a grown-up."

3-5: "No. Don't send money, gift cards, or game currency to someone who is scaring you. Tell a trusted adult right away."

6-8: "No. Paying usually leads to more demands. Stop talking to them, take screenshots, and tell a trusted adult. You will not be in trouble."

9-12: "Experts, including law enforcement, advise against paying, because payment commonly leads to more demands [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: NCMEC says cooperating or paying rarely stops the blackmail; FBI wording could not be read by automated checks]. Stop responding, preserve the account name and messages, report to the platform and the CyberTipline, and tell a trusted adult. If money has already been sent, say so; it is useful information and not a reason for shame."

10 Will my parents take my phone if I tell them?

K-2: "A grown-up might make a new rule, but their job is to help. Telling is still the right thing to do."

3-5: "Sometimes grown-ups worry and change the rules. Most of the time they are just scared because they love you. You can say: 'I told you because I want help, not to get in trouble.'"

6-8: "I can't control what your family decides, and I understand that fear. A good way to start is: 'I need to tell you something and I need you to listen first.' If you're worried, I can be there when you talk to them, or the counselor can help. Telling is how problems get solved faster."

9-12: "It's a real concern, and many teens put off telling for exactly this reason. You can ask for a 'help first, rules later' conversation. I can help you plan what to say, or join you or the counselor in the conversation. Our Family Tech Agreement guidance encourages families to promise not to punish a child for telling." [Do not promise the outcome of a family's decisions.]

11 How do I know if a picture or video is fake?

K-2: "Pictures and voices can be made up, like cartoons. If a picture or video seems strange or makes you feel funny, ask a grown-up to look with you."

3-5: "Look for things that seem off, like strange hands, blurry edges, or words that don't make sense. The best habit is to ask: Who made this, and why? When unsure, ask a trusted adult and don't share."

6-8: "Sometimes you can spot clues, but tools are getting better, so clues are not enough. Check where it came from, see if reliable sources show the same thing, and pause on content that makes you very angry or scared fast. If it is about a real person you know, don't forward it."

9-12: "Visual clues are an unreliable test. Use provenance: who first posted it, whether trusted outlets confirm it, whether reverse search shows an original, and whether the platform labels it. Emotional intensity and urgency are red flags. Because detection is imperfect, 'I cannot be sure' is a legitimate conclusion, and not sharing is a reasonable default."

12 Can someone make a fake picture of me?

K-2: "Yes, computers can make pretend pictures. If you ever see one of you that is not real or is yucky, tell a grown-up. It is not your fault."

3-5: "Yes, some tools can change pictures or make fake ones. That is why we are careful about posting pictures. If a fake one of you appears, tell a trusted adult. It is never your fault."

6-8: "Yes, and some people misuse apps to make fake or sexual pictures of classmates. That is abuse, even when the image is fake, and creating or sharing it can be illegal [Law varies by state; confirm with district counsel]. If it happens to you, it is not your fault. Save evidence without sharing, tell a trusted adult, report it on the platform, and we will help."

9-12: "Yes. AI 'nudify' tools and manipulated images exist, and surveys suggest that a meaningful minority of teens know someone targeted (Thorn: about 1 in 8 knew someone who was the target of deepfake nudes, and about 1 in 17 say it happened to them) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: thorn.org]. It's abuse regardless of whether the image is real. Federal law now criminalizes publishing non-consensual intimate imagery, including digital forgeries, and covered platforms must have a removal process and act within 48 hours of a valid request (in effect since May 19, 2026) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: congress.gov Public Law 119-12; ftc.gov; consult counsel on how it applies]. Report it, use Take It Down, and tell a trusted adult."

13 Is it okay to talk to an AI chatbot like a friend?

K-2: "A chatbot is a computer program. It can be fun to use with a grown-up, but it is not a real person and it doesn't really know you. Real friends and grown-ups are the ones who can hug you and help."

3-5: "Chatbots can answer questions and be fun, but they are programs. They can be wrong, and they don't really feel things. For worries, big feelings, or anything scary, talk to a trusted person."

6-8: "Chatbots can feel caring because they are built to sound that way. They can also be wrong, agree with you too easily, and store what you type. It's okay to use them for homework help or fun, but for serious worries, a real person is the right choice."

9-12: "Many teens use AI companions and chatbots, and surveys suggest a notable share use them for serious conversations (Common Sense, 2025: about 1 in 3 AI-companion users chose an AI over a person for serious matters; Pew, Dec 2025: 64% of teens use chatbots) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]. Consider that these systems are designed to be engaging, may validate rather than challenge, can be inaccurate, and may retain what you share. They can be a tool; they are not a substitute for people who can act in a crisis. For anything involving harm, self-harm, or abuse, tell a human, or call or text 988."

14 Can AI keep my secrets?

K-2: "A computer program is not a safe place for secrets. Tell secrets that worry you to a grown-up."

3-5: "No. What you type into a chatbot might be saved, and a person or company may see it. Don't share your address, school, passwords, or private things."

6-8: "Not reliably. Companies may store conversations and use them to improve products, depending on their policy. Treat a chatbot like a public place: don't share personal details, other people's secrets, or anything you wouldn't want saved."

9-12: "Assume data may be retained, reviewed, or used for training unless the service clearly states otherwise [VERIFY by service]. There is no confidentiality like a counselor's. Avoid sharing identifying details, sensitive images, or other people's private information with chatbots."

15 Why do apps want my information?

K-2: "Sometimes apps ask for your name or picture. You can ask a grown-up first before giving any answers."

3-5: "Some apps collect information to work, and some collect it to make money by showing ads. Ask: Does it really need this? If you are unsure, ask a grown-up."

6-8: "Many free apps earn money from data about you, such as interests and habits, used for advertising. Check permissions. A flashlight app that wants your contacts is a warning sign. You can turn off permissions you do not need."

9-12: "Data is the product in many business models. It is collected, combined, and sometimes sold through data brokers. Review permissions, location sharing and ad settings, and use opt-out tools where they exist. Be aware that privacy law protections vary by state and age [VERIFY]."

16 Can people really find where I live from a picture?

K-2: "Pictures can show clues like your house or school. We only share pictures with grown-ups' help."

3-5: "Yes, sometimes. A picture can show your street sign, school shirt, or a landmark. Little clues add up. Ask a grown-up before posting."

6-8: "Yes, it can happen. Backgrounds, school logos, tagged places and sometimes hidden location data in photos can give clues, and people can combine small details. Check backgrounds, turn off location tags, and keep your posts private."

9-12: "Yes. Metadata, background details, location sharing, and combining posts across accounts can reveal where you live, study, or hang out. Review location settings, audit what is visible to strangers, and think about permanence before you post."

17 What if I clicked on something bad?

K-2: "That's okay. Everybody clicks by accident. Use your Oops Button: stop, close your eyes or look away, and tell a grown-up. You are not in trouble."

3-5: "Don't panic. Everyone makes mistakes. Close it, don't type anything, and tell a trusted adult. The Oops Recovery steps are: stop, tell, change passwords if needed, and learn."

6-8: "Mistakes happen, even to experts. If you entered a password, change it right away and turn on two-step verification. Tell an adult so they can check your device and accounts. The sooner you tell, the easier the fix."

9-12: "Treat it as an incident, not a failure. Disconnect if needed, change passwords from a clean device, enable two-step verification, check account recovery options and logged-in devices, and report to your school's IT or a trusted adult. If it involved payment or personal data, tell someone quickly."

18 Why do some people hack, and is hacking always bad?

K-2: (If raised) "Some people try to get into other people's computers, and that's not okay. Other people help keep computers safe."

3-5: "Some people break in for bad reasons. Others, called ethical hackers, get permission to find weak spots so they can fix them. The key is permission."

6-8: "Hackers have different motives, such as money, curiosity, or protest. Breaking into someone's account or system without permission is illegal, even if you are 'just testing.' Ethical hackers work with permission and follow rules. There are legal ways to practice, like free capture-the-flag games."

9-12: "Motives include profit, ideology, curiosity, and criminal organization. Unauthorized access is illegal under laws such as the Computer Fraud and Abuse Act [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: law.cornell.edu/uscode/text/18/1030], and 'I was just looking' is not a defense. Security careers rely on authorization and ethics, and free CTFs and programs offer legal ways to build skills. This curriculum teaches defense and recognition, not attack methods."

19 What if my friend is being hurt online and asks me not to tell?

K-2: "If a friend is being hurt or is scared, tell a grown-up. That is what a good friend does."

3-5: "You can say, 'I want to help you.' Then tell a trusted adult, even if your friend asked you not to. You can stay kind and stay with your friend."

6-8: "Being a good friend sometimes means doing what feels uncomfortable. Encourage your friend to tell, offer to go with them, and if they won't, tell a trusted adult yourself. You are not betraying them. You are helping."

9-12: "Supporting a friend includes listening without judgment and not promising secrecy about serious harm. Encourage them to talk to an adult, offer to go along, and escalate if they are at risk of self-harm or ongoing

abuse. You are not responsible for fixing it alone, and you shouldn't carry it alone either. Take care of yourself, too."

20 **Everyone else is on that app. Why can't I be?**

K-2: "Families have different rules, like bedtimes. Your grown-ups pick rules to keep you safe."

3-5: "Many apps have age limits because they weren't designed for younger kids. Your family may pick different rules. It's okay to feel left out, and you can ask your family why."

6-8: "It feels unfair when friends have something you don't. Age minimums exist partly because of privacy law and design concerns [VERIFY by app]. A good way to approach it is to ask your family what would need to be true for them to say yes, like privacy settings or check-ins."

9-12: "Social pressure is real, and so are risks, and both can be true. Many platforms set minimum ages, and some jurisdictions are tightening them [VERIFY]. Make your case with a plan: privacy settings, time limits, and an agreement on what you will tell a parent about."

21 **What if I am the one who was mean?**

K-2: "Everybody can make a mistake. Say sorry, ask how you can help, and try again."

3-5: "That's brave to admit. Stop, take it down if it's online, apologize sincerely, and do something kind. You can learn from it."

6-8: "People do hurtful things, sometimes by joining in. You can still repair it. Stop, delete or remove the post, apologize without excuses, and ask a trusted adult for help. Being honest now matters." [Be clear if school policy has consequences, and consult it.]

9-12: "Accountability is a skill. Stop the behavior, remove what you can, apologize directly without asking to be forgiven, and consider whether anything you shared could be illegal, such as a private image, a threat, or a fake. If so, talk to a trusted adult or counselor right away." [Consult counsel and policy.]

22 Do deleted messages and pictures really go away?

K-2: "Once something is shared, it might not disappear. That's why we ask a grown-up first."

3-5: "Not always. Someone can take a screenshot before you delete it. That is why we think before we send."

6-8: "Often not completely. Screenshots, forwards, and backups mean a deleted message may still exist. This is why you should pause before you send, and why you should not rely on 'disappearing' features."

9-12: "Treat anything sent as potentially permanent. Recipients can screenshot or save, platforms may keep copies, and 'disappearing' messages are not guaranteed to disappear. If you need to remove something, there are takedown tools, but prevention is stronger."

23 How come adults say "don't talk to strangers" but my online friend isn't a stranger?

K-2: "Good question. A person you only know online can still be someone you don't really know. If a grown-up you trust doesn't know them, check with them first."

3-5: "People online can seem like friends but still be someone pretending. The better rule is: only share personal information with people your trusted adults know. And you can always tell us if someone makes you feel uneasy."

6-8: "You're right that 'stranger danger' is too simple. Many risks come from someone who has built trust over time. Look at behavior: secrecy, pressure, gifts, moving to private chats, requests for pictures. If you see that, it's time to stop and tell someone."

9-12: "Right, and the research agrees: most harmful online contact starts as a seemingly friendly or peer-like connection. The more useful question is what the person is doing: building secrecy, escalating intimacy, testing boundaries, or pressuring. Judge behavior, not labels."

24 What if I'm too embarrassed to tell anyone?

K-2: "It's okay to feel shy. You can tell a grown-up by whispering, drawing a picture, or using the signal we practiced."

3-5: "Lots of people feel embarrassed. You can write a note, draw, or say, 'I have a worry.' You do not have to say everything at once."

6-8: "Embarrassment is very common, and it is exactly what people who want to hurt you count on. You can start with 'I need help but I'm not ready to say everything.' You can also write it or send it to a counselor."

9-12: "Shame is the biggest reason people stay silent, and it's also the least accurate guide. You can begin small: 'Something happened online and I need advice.' You can use a written note, an email to a counselor, or a helpline, such as NCMEC, 988, or Crisis Text Line (text HOME to 741741) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: crisistextline.org]."

25 What happens after I tell a teacher?

K-2: "I listen, I say thank you, and I get another grown-up whose job is to help. You are not in trouble."

3-5: "I'll listen and thank you. Then I'll tell someone like the counselor or principal who can help. I can't keep it a secret if you are hurt or in danger, but I will tell you who I'm telling."

6-8: "I will listen, believe you, and tell you what I have to do next. I may need to share it with the counselor, an administrator, or people who protect kids. I'll tell you who and why, and I'll check in on you afterward."

9-12: "I'll listen, tell you what I'm required to report and to whom, and avoid making promises I cannot keep. Depending on what you tell me, I may need to contact child protective services or law enforcement, and the counselor will be involved. You'll hear what's happening as much as possible, and you will not be left to handle it alone." [Adjust to your state and policy; consult counsel.]

These answers are educational guidance, not legal advice. Statistics and legal claims marked [VERIFY] must be confirmed against current primary sources before printing or presenting.